

The modern jihadi could be the product and beneficiary of a liberal democracy like India. He would use every aspect of freedom it has to offer for the perpetuation of hate.

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uct and the beneficiary of a liberal democracy like India. He would use every aspect of freedom it has to offer for the perpetuation of hate, for making the war against civilisation fool-proof. He would employ every technological trick of the satanic enemy for the success of his mission. His allegiance is not to the flag of his country; his identity is not defined by his nationality. He is the citizen of a scriptural make believe; he is here on a sacred assignment.

Still, the India after November 26 is a different country. For once, there is a confluence of grief and anger and patriotism. This time, there is no dispute about the nationality of the terrorist; there is little doubt about the identity of his benefactor either. The nation has ceased to be a dirty word across the ideological divide, though the communists refuse to change. The politician has not been

allowed hawk terror for the preservation of the vote bank, and someone called A.R. Antulay looks convincingly repulsive as he scavenges the debris for postponing his political redundancy. The rage of the terrorist has sharpened our perception about the enemy: Pakistan is not just an Indian obsession, or a diversionary bogeyman; the Islamic Republic is the original Jihadistan, our unrepentant tormentor. The terrorist has also forced us to look within. Our failure in national security is huge, and we are beginning to accept the reality that the war on terror is not always someone else's war. It's our war too. The world has survived the ideology that built some of the biggest graveyards in history, and the world will overcome the theology that terrorises us with its medieval fury. The Newsmaker of the year won't be the maker of our destiny, *Inshallah*.